- **Buy through your employer.** Not all employers will pay for disability coverage. But a growing number of employers now have systems in place to let employees *buy* individual coverage on a voluntary basis. These arrangements can cost significantly less than what you might pay for a policy on your own, especially if you're a woman. Believe it or not, women can generally expect to pay up to 40% more than men for individual disability insurance. (Again, it's because insurers characterize pregnancy as a disability.) But if you buy a policy through your job, you're protected by workplace equality laws. Check with your human resources department to see whether you have this option.
- **Decrease your benefit period.** Relatively few disabilities last more than five years. In fact, most last less than two years. If you're willing to accept the risk, you can save up to 35% of your premium by accepting a benefit period of only five years, instead of being insured until you retire.
- **Limit yourself to emergency coverage.** If you can't afford a full-scale disability policy, look into coverage that will kick in only in a worst-case scenario, such as a debilitating accident or a catastrophic illness like a heart attack or a stroke. These no-frills disability policies have very short benefit periods (they'll typically pay for just one or two years) and generally cost about $200 to $300 a year.
- **Find less-extreme hobbies.** Remember, disability insurance differs from workers comp by covering you if you have an accident off the job. As a result, someone who does a lot of kiteboarding or rock climbing, for example, should expect to pay higher premiums than someone who doesn't (or be prepared to have the insurer include a clause that says you're not covered if you hurt yourself while chasing your thrills). I know this one may sound annoying, but it's true.

HOME INSURANCE